

‘To ordinary men, perhaps not;—but to me—to me, whose every minute is worth a treasure. Tell me, Guénaud, tell me!’

‘No, no, my lord.’

‘I insist upon it, I tell you. Oh! give me a month, and for every one of those thirty days I will pay you a hundred thousand crowns.’

‘My lord,’ replied Guénaud, in a firm voice, ‘it is God who can give you days of grace, and not I. God only allows you a fortnight.’

The cardinal breathed a painful sigh, and sank back down upon his pillow, murmuring, ‘Thank you, Guénaud, thank you!’

The physician was about to depart; the dying man, raising himself up: ‘Silence!’ said he, with flaming eyes, ‘silence!’

‘My lord, I have known this secret two months; you see that I have kept it faithfully.’

‘Go, Guénaud; I will take care of your fortunes; go, and tell Brienne to send me a clerk called M. Colbert. Go!’

Chapter XLIV

Colbert



COLBERT was not far off. During the whole evening he had remained in one of the corridors, chatting with Bernouin and Brienne, and commenting, with the ordinary skill of people of court, upon the news which developed like air-bubbles upon the water, on the surface of each event. It is doubtless time to trace, in a few words, one of the most interesting portraits of the age, and to trace it with as much truth, perhaps, as contemporary painters have been able to do. Colbert was a man in whom the historian and the moralist have an equal right.

He was thirteen years older than Louis XIV, his future master. Of middle height, rather lean than otherwise, he had deep-set eyes, a mean appearance, his hair was coarse, black and thin, which, say the biographers of his time, made him take early to the skull-cap. A look of severity, of harshness even, a sort of stiffness, which, with inferiors, was pride, with superiors an affectation of superior virtue; a surly cast of countenance upon all occasions, even when looking at himself in a glass alone—such is the exterior of his personage. As to the moral part of his character, the depth of his talent for accounts, and his ingenuity in making sterility itself productive, were much boasted of. Colbert had formed the idea of forcing governors of frontier places to feed the garrisons without pay, with what they drew from contributions. Such a valuable quality made Mazarin think of replacing Joubert, his intendant, who had recently died, by M. Colbert, who had such skill in nibbling down allowances. Colbert by degrees crept into court, notwithstanding his lowly birth, for he was the son of a man who sold wine as his father had done, but who afterwards sold cloth, and then silk stuffs. Colbert, destined for trade, had been clerk

in Lyons to a merchant, whom he had quitted to come to Paris in the office of a Châtelet procureur named Biterne. It was here he learned the art of drawing up an account, and the much more valuable one of complicating it.

This stiffness of manner in Colbert had been of great service to him; it is so true that Fortune, when she has a caprice, resembles those women of antiquity, who, when they had a fancy, were disgusted by no physical or moral defects in either men or things. Colbert, placed with Michel Letellier, secretary of state in 1648, by his cousin Colbert, Seigneur de Saint-Penange, who protected him, received one day from the minister a commission for Cardinal Mazarin. His eminence was then in the enjoyment of flourishing health, and the bad years of the Fronde had not yet counted triple and quadruple for him. He was at Sedan, very much annoyed at a court intrigue in which Anne of Austria seemed inclined to desert his cause.

Of this intrigue Letellier held the thread. He had just received a letter from Anne of Austria, a letter very valuable to him, and strongly promising Mazarin; but, as he already played the double part which served him so well, and by which he always managed two enemies so as to draw advantage from both, either by embroiling them more and more or by reconciling them, Michel Letellier wished to send Anne of Austria's letter to Mazarin, in order that he might be acquainted with it, and consequently pleased with his having so willingly rendered him a service. To send the letter was an easy matter; to recover it again, after having communicated it, that was the difficulty. Letellier cast his eyes around him, and seeing the black and meagre clerk with the scowling brow, scribbling away in his office, he preferred him to the best gendarme for the execution of this design.

Colbert was commanded to set out for Sedan, with positive orders to carry the letter to Mazarin, and bring it back to Letellier. He listened to his orders with scrupulous attention, required the instructions to be repeated twice, and was particular in learning whether the bringing back was as necessary as the communicating, and Letellier replied sternly, 'More necessary.' Then he set out, travelled like a courier, without any care for his body, and placed in the hands of Mazarin, first a letter from Letellier, which announced to the cardinal the sending of the precious letter, and

His eminence sank down for a moment, like an unfortunate wretch who is crushed by a falling column. But the spirit of Mazarin was a strong one, or rather his mind was a firm one. 'Guénaud,' said he, recovering from his first shock, 'you will permit me to appeal from your judgment. I will call together the most learned men of Europe: I will consult them. I will live, in short, by the virtue of I care not what remedy.'

'My lord must not suppose,' said Guénaud, 'that I have the presumption to pronounce alone upon an existence so valuable as yours. I have already assembled all the good physicians and practitioners of France and Europe. There were twelve of them.'

'And they said—'

'They said that your eminence was suffering from a mortal disease; I have the consultation signed in my portfolio. If your eminence will please to see it, you will find the names of all the incurable diseases we have met with. There is first—'

'No, no,' cried Mazarin, pushing away the paper. 'No, no, Guénaud, I yield! I yield!' And a profound silence, during which the cardinal resumed his senses and recovered his strength, succeeded to the agitation of this scene. 'There is another thing,' murmured Mazarin; 'there are empirics and charlatans. In my country, those whom physicians abandon run the chance of a quack, who kills them ten times but saves them a hundred times.'

'Has not your eminence observed, that during the last month I have changed my remedies ten times?'

'Yes. Well?'

'Well, I have spent fifty thousand crowns in purchasing the secrets of all these fellows: the list is exhausted, and so is my purse. You are not cured: and, but for my art, you would be dead.'

'That ends it!' murmured the cardinal; 'that ends it.' And he threw a melancholy look upon the riches which surrounded him. 'And must I quit all that?' sighed he. 'I am dying, Guénaud! I am dying!'

'Oh! not yet, my lord,' said the physician.

Mazarin seized his hand. 'In what time?' asked he, fixing his two large eyes upon the impassible countenance of the physician.

'My lord, we never tell that.'

‘Oh! my lord, you are much more than that. How long did the Fronde last?’

‘For what purpose do you put such a question to me?’

‘For a medical calculation, monseigneur.’

‘Well, some ten years—off and on.’

‘Very well; be kind enough to reckon every year of the Fronde as three years—that makes thirty; now twenty and fifty-two makes seventy-two years. You are seventy-two, my lord; and that is a great age.’

Whilst saying this, he felt the pulse of his patient. This pulse was full of such fatal indications, that the physician continued, notwithstanding the interruptions of the patient: ‘Put down the years of the Fronde at four each, and you have lived eighty-two years.’

‘Are you speaking seriously, Guénaud?’

‘Alas! yes, monseigneur.’

‘You take a roundabout way, then, to inform me that I am very ill?’

‘*Ma foi!* yes, my lord, and with a man of the mind and courage of your eminence, it ought not to be necessary to do so.’

The cardinal breathed with such difficulty that he inspired pity even in a pitiless physician. ‘There are diseases and diseases,’ resumed Mazarin.

‘From some of them people escape.’

‘That is true, my lord.’

‘Is it not?’ cried Mazarin, almost joyously; ‘for, in short, what else would be the use of power, of strength of will? What would the use of genius be—your genius, Guénaud? What would be the use of science and art, if the patient, who disposes of all that, cannot be saved from peril?’

Guénaud was about to open his mouth, but Mazarin continued:

‘Remember,’ said he, ‘I am the most confiding of your patients; remember I obey you blindly, and that consequently—’

‘I know all that,’ said Guénaud.

‘I shall be cured, then?’

‘Monseigneur, there is neither strength of will, nor power, nor genius, nor science that can resist a disease which God doubtless sends, or which He cast upon the earth at the creation, with full power to destroy and kill mankind. When the disease is mortal, and nothing can—’

‘Is—my—disease—mortal?’ asked Mazarin.

‘Yes, my lord.’

then that letter itself. Mazarin coloured greatly whilst reading Anne of Austria’s letter, gave Colbert a gracious smile and dismissed him.

‘When shall I have the answer, monseigneur?’

‘To-morrow.’

‘To-morrow morning?’

‘Yes, monsieur.’

The clerk turned upon his heel, after making his very best bow. The next day he was at his post at seven o’clock. Mazarin made him wait till ten. He remained patiently in the ante-chamber; his turn having come, he entered; Mazarin gave him a sealed packet. On the envelope of this packet were these words:—Monsieur Michel Letellier, etc. Colbert looked at the packet with much attention; the cardinal put on a pleasant countenance and pushed him towards the door.

‘And the letter of the queen-mother, my lord?’ asked Colbert.

‘It is in with the rest, in the packet,’ said Mazarin.

‘Oh! very well,’ replied Colbert; and placing his hat between his knees, he began to unseal the packet.

Mazarin uttered a cry. ‘What are you doing?’ said he, angrily.

‘I am unsealing the packet, my lord.’

‘You mistrust me, then, master pedant, do you? Did any one ever see such impertinence?’

‘Oh! my lord, do not be angry with me! It is certainly not your eminence’s word I place in doubt, God forbid!’

‘What then?’

‘It is the careflessness of your chancery, my lord. What is a letter? A rag. May not a rag be forgotten? And look, my lord, look if I was not right. Your clerks have forgotten the rag; the letter is not in the packet.’

‘You are an insolent fellow, and you have not looked,’ cried Mazarin, very angrily; ‘begone and wait my pleasure.’ Whilst saying these words, with perfectly Italian subtlety he snatched the packet from the hands of Colbert, and re-entered his apartments.

But this anger could not last so long as to be replaced in time by reason. Mazarin, every morning, on opening his closet door, found the figure of Colbert like a sentinel behind the bench, and this disagreeable figure never failed to ask him humbly, but with tenacity, for the queen-mother’s letter. Mazarin could hold out no longer, and was obliged to give it up.

He accompanied this restitution with a most severe reprimand, during which Colbert contented himself with examining, feeling, even smelling, as it were, the paper, the characters, and the signature, neither more nor less than if he had to deal with the greatest forger in the kingdom. Mazarin behaved still more rudely to him, but Colbert, still impassible, having obtained a certainty that the letter was the true one, went off as if he had been deaf. This conduct obtained for him afterwards the post of Joubert; for Mazarin, instead of bearing malice, admired him, and was desirous of attaching so much fidelity to himself.

It may be judged by this single anecdote, what the character of Colbert was. Events, developing themselves, by degrees allowed all the powers of his mind to act freely. Colbert was not long in insinuating himself to the good graces of the cardinal: he became even indispensable to him. The clerk was acquainted with all his accounts without the cardinal's ever having spoken to him about them. This secret between them was a powerful tie, and this was why, when about to appear before the Master of another world, Mazarin was desirous of taking good counsel in disposing the wealth he was so unwillingly obliged to leave in this world. After the visit of Guénaud, he therefore sent for Colbert, desired him to sit down, and said to him: 'Let us converse, Monsieur Colbert, and seriously, for I am very ill, and I may chance to die.'

'Man is mortal,' replied Colbert.

'I have always remembered that, M. Colbert, and I have worked with that end in view. You know that I have amassed a little wealth.'

'I know you have, monseigneur.'

'At how much do you estimate, as near as you can, the amount of this wealth, M. Colbert?'

'At forty millions, five hundred and sixty thousand, two hundred livres, nine cents, eight farthings,' replied Colbert.

The cardinal heaved a deep sigh, and looked at Colbert with wonder, but he allowed a smile to steal across his lips.

'Known money,' added Colbert, in reply to that smile.

The cardinal gave quite a start in bed. 'What do you mean by that?' said he.

Chapter XLIII

Guénaud



HE cardinal's order was pressing; Guénaud quickly obeyed it. He found his patient stretched on his bed, his legs swelled, his face livid, and his stomach collapsed. Mazarin had a severe attack of gout. He suffered tortures with the impatience of a man who has not been accustomed to resistances. On seeing Guénaud: 'Ah!' said he; 'now I am saved!'

Guénaud was a very learned and circumspect man, who stood in no need of the critiques of Boileau to obtain a reputation. When facing a disease, if it were personified in a king, he treated the patient as a Turk treats a Moor. He did not, therefore, reply to Mazarin as the minister expected: 'Here is the doctor; good-bye disease!' On the contrary, on examining his patient, with a very serious air:

'Oh! oh!' said he.

'Eh! what! Guénaud! How you look at me!'

'I look as I should on seeing your complaint, my lord; it is a very dangerous one.'

'The gout—oh! yes, the gout.'

'With complications, my lord.'

Mazarin raised himself upon his elbow, and, questioning by look and gesture: 'What do you mean by that? Am I worse than I believe myself to be?'

'My lord,' said Guénaud, seating himself beside the bed; 'your eminence has worked very hard during your life; your eminence has suffered much.'

'But I am not old, I fancy. The late M. de Richelieu was but seventeen months younger than I am when he died, and died of a mortal disease. I am young, Guénaud: remember, I am scarcely fifty-two.'

'I mean,' said Colbert, 'that besides those forty millions, five hundred and sixty thousand, two hundred livres, nine cents, eight farthings, there are thirteen millions that are not known.'

'Ouf!' sighed Mazarin, 'what a man!'

At this moment, the head of Bernouin appeared through the embrasure of the door.

'What is it?' asked Mazarin, 'and why do you disturb me?'

'The Théatin father, your eminence's director, was sent for this evening; and he cannot come again to my lord till after to-morrow.'

Mazarin looked at Colbert, who rose and took his hat, saying: 'I shall come again, my lord.'

Mazarin hesitated. 'No, no,' said he; 'I have as much business to transact with you as with him. Besides, you are my other confessor—and what I have to say to one the other may hear. Remain where you are, Colbert.'

'But my lord, if there be no secret of penitence, will the director consent to my being here?'

'Do not trouble yourself about that; come into the ruelle.'

'I can wait outside, monseigneur.'

'No, no, it will do you good to hear the confession of a rich man.'

Colbert bowed and went into the ruelle.

'Introduce the Théatin father,' said Mazarin, closing the curtains.

Chapter 42: In Which Mazarin Becomes Prodigal

'our swords are once more to be hung on the wall—for a long time!' and he sighed.

All that sigh contained of ambition silently stifled, of extinguished illusions and disappointed hopes, Athos alone divined, for he alone heard that sigh. Immediately after, the prince took leave and the king left the apartment. Athos, by a sign made to Bragelonne, renewed the desire he had expressed at the beginning of the scene. By degrees the chamber was deserted, and Mazarin was left alone, a prey to suffering which he could no longer dissemble. 'Bernouin! Bernouin!' cried he in a broken voice.

'What does monseigneur want?'

'Guénaud—let Guénaud be sent for,' said his eminence. 'I think I'm dying.'

Bernouin, in great terror, rushed into the cabinet to give the order, and the piqueur, who hastened to fetch the physician, passed the king's carriage in the Rue Saint-Honoré.

'Yes, my lord, very ill, without doubt; he looks very ill, as your royal highness may perceive.'

'But surely he will die of it. A hundred and fifty thousand livres! Oh, it is incredible! But, comte, tell me a reason for it?'

'Patience, monseigneur, I beg of you. Here comes M. le Duc d'Anjou, talking with the Chevalier de Lorraine; I should not be surprised if they spared us the trouble of being indiscreet. Listen to them.'

In fact the chevalier said to the prince in a low voice, 'My lord, it is not natural for M. Mazarin to give you so much money. Take care! you will let some of the pieces fall, my lord. What design has the cardinal upon you to make him so generous?'

'As I said,' whispered Athos in the prince's ear, 'that, perhaps, is the best reply to your question.'

'Tell me, my lord,' repeated the chevalier impatiently, as he was calculating, by weighing them in his pocket, the quota of the sum which had fallen to his share by rebound.

'My dear chevalier, a wedding present.'

'How a wedding present?'

'Eh! yes, I am going to be married,' replied the Duc d'Anjou, without perceiving, at the moment, he was passing the prince and Athos, who both bowed respectfully.

The chevalier darted at the young duke a glance so strange, and so malicious, that the Comte de la Fère quite started on beholding it.

'You! you to be married!' repeated he; 'oh! that's impossible. You would not commit such a folly!'

'Bah! I don't do it myself; I am made to do it,' replied the Duc d'Anjou. 'But come, quick! let us get rid of our money.' Thereupon he disappeared with his companion, laughing and talking, whilst all heads were bowed on his passage.

'Then,' whispered the prince to Athos, 'that is the secret.'

'It was not I who told you so, my lord.'

'He is to marry the sister of Charles II?'

'I believe so.'

The prince reflected for a moment, and his eye shot forth one of its not infrequent flashes. 'Humph!' said he slowly, as if speaking to himself;

Chapter XLV

Confession of a Man of Wealth



HE Théatin entered deliberately, without being too much astonished at the noise and agitation which anxiety for the cardinal's health had raised in his household. 'Come in, my reverend father,' said Mazarin, after a last look at the ruelle, 'come in and console me.'

'That is my duty, my lord,' replied the Théatin.

'Begin by sitting down, and making yourself comfortable, for I am going to begin with a general confession; you will afterwards give me a good absolution, and I shall believe myself more tranquil.'

'My lord,' said the father, 'you are not so ill as to make a general confession urgent—and it will be very fatiguing—take care.'

'You suspect, then, that it may be long, father?'

'How can I think it otherwise, when a man has lived so completely as your eminence has done?'

'Ah! that is true!—yes—the recital may be long.'

'The mercy of God is great,' snuffed the Théatin.

'Stop,' said Mazarin; 'there I begin to terrify myself with having allowed so many things to pass which the Lord might reprove.'

'Is that not always so?' said the Théatin naively, removing further from the lamp his thin pointed face, like that of a mole. 'Sinners are so forgetful beforehand, and scrupulous when it is too late.' 'Sinners?' replied Mazarin. 'Do you use that word ironically, and to reproach me

with all the genealogies I have allowed to be made on my account—I—the son of a fisherman, in fact?¹

‘Hum!’ said the Thérain.

‘That is a first sin, father; for I have allowed myself made to descend from two old Roman consuls, S. Geganius Macerinus 1st, Macerinus 2d, and Proculus Macerinus 3d, of whom the *Chronicle* of Haolander speaks. From Macerinus to Mazarin the proximity was tempting. Macerinus, a diminutive, means leanish, poorish, out of case. Oh! reverend father! Mazarini may now be carried to the augmentative Maigre, thin as Lazarus. Look!’—and he showed his fleshless arms.

‘In your having been born of a family of fishermen I see nothing injurious to you; for—St Peter was a fisherman; and if you are a prince of the church, my lord, he was the supreme head of it. Pass on, if you please.’

‘So much the more for my having threatened with the Bastille a certain Bounet, a priest of Avignon, who wanted to publish a genealogy of the Casa Mazarini much too marvellous.’

‘To be probable?’ replied the Thérain.

‘Oh! if I had acted up to his idea, father, that would have been the vice of pride—another sin.’

‘It was an excess of wit, and a person is not to be reproached with such sorts of abuses. Pass on!’

‘I was all pride. Look you, father, I will endeavour to divide that into capital sins.’

‘I like divisions, when well made.’

‘I am glad of that. You must know that in 1630—alas! that is thirty-one years ago—’

‘You were then twenty-nine years old, monseigneur.’

‘A hot-headed age. I was then something of a soldier, and I threw myself at Casal into the arquebusades, to show that I rode on horseback as well as an officer. It is true, I restored peace between the French and the Spaniards. That redeems my sin a little.’

¹This is quite untranslatable—it being a play upon the words *pêcheur* (with a grave over the first e), a sinner, and *pêcheur* (with an accent circumflex over the first e), a fisherman.—TRANS.

‘Stop, monseigneur, listen to what is being said yonder, at the table of my lord the cardinal.’

‘Where they are playing?’

‘Yes, my lord.’

The cardinal had just raised himself on one elbow, and made a sign to the king’s brother, who went to him.

‘My lord,’ said the cardinal, ‘pick up, if you please, all those gold crowns.’ And he pointed to the enormous pile of yellow and glittering pieces which the Comte de Guiche had raised by degrees before him by a surprising run of luck at play.

‘For me?’ cried the Duc d’Anjou.

‘Those fifty thousand crowns; yes, monseigneur, they are yours.’

‘Do you give them to me?’

‘I have been playing on your account, monseigneur,’ replied the cardinal, getting weaker and weaker, as if this effort of giving money had exhausted all his physical and moral faculties.

‘Oh, good heavens!’ exclaimed Philip, wild with joy, ‘what a fortunate day! And he himself, making a rake of his fingers, drew a part of the sum into his pockets, which he filled, and still full a third remained on the table.’

‘Chevalier,’ said Philip to his favourite, the Chevalier de Lorraine, ‘come hither, chevalier.’ The favourite quickly obeyed. ‘Pocket the rest,’ said the young prince.

This singular scene was considered by the persons present only as a touching kind of family fête. The cardinal assumed the airs of a father with the sons of France, and the two princes had grown up under his wing. No one then imputed to pride, or even impertinence, as would be done nowadays, this liberality on the part of the first minister. The courtiers were satisfied with envying the prince.—The king turned away his head.

‘I never had so much money before,’ said the young prince, joyously, as he crossed the chamber with his favourite to go to his carriage. ‘No, never! What a weight these crowns are!’

‘But why has monsieur le cardinal given away all this money at once?’ asked M. le Prince of the Comte de la Fère. ‘He must be very ill, the dear cardinal!’